

## Chapter 43-2: Like

The path up the mountain was very long. Chu Qingqiu didn't ride her sword but walked alongside Jiang Li the entire way. Jiang Li had a lively personality and loved to talk. Upon reaching Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, she found everything novel and asked about everything she saw.

Most of those questions were answered by Qiu Yi, and Chu Qingqiu would speak up for only a few. But even so, Ning Fuyi felt stuffy inside, staring blankly at the steps and nearly tripping herself several times.

"This statue is quite interesting—it looks like a donkey. Who cast it?" Jiang Li said in surprise, looking at a bronze statue by the roadside. "Placing it at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate with all its birdsong and fragrant flowers is quite striking."

"Ning Changfeng," Chu Qingqiu answered briefly.

"Why?" Jiang Li's delicate jade hand touched the donkey's head.

"To ward off evil," Chu Qingqiu said.

Jiang Li had an expression of sudden understanding. Her gaze inadvertently glanced at Ning Fuyi, who had been following behind them, and dimples appeared on her cheeks: "This disciple is still young but quite good-looking. Her features are seventy percent similar to Sect Leader Ningtian<sup>1</sup>. This must be Ning Fuyi?"

Chu Qingqiu nodded and turned left at the fork, leading Jiang Li toward Tranquil Mountain Palace.

"That sword of hers seems quite good," Jiang Li said thoughtfully, touching her own smooth forehead.

Jiang Li had come here only for Chu Qingqiu, and since treating injuries shouldn't be publicized, she hadn't alerted others to come welcome her. However, Chu Qingqiu still called some immortal attendants from the sect to Tranquil Mountain Palace so they wouldn't receive guests too coldly.

Ning Fuyi had been following at a distance the whole way, but when they reached the vicinity of Tranquil Mountain Palace, she was stopped by Qiu Yi, who looked her up and down: "We've already reached Tranquil Mountain Palace. What are you still following for?"

"Who says I'm following you? This is the path to Suspended Beam Garden. I'm just going to cultivate," Ning Fuyi said, raising her head with a light laugh.

"You..."

"Young Sect Leader." Suddenly, a voice filled with laughter called from ahead. Ning Fuyi looked up to see that Jiang Li had somehow stopped and turned back to smile at her gracefully. "I've had a few encounters with Sect Leader Ningtian. If you don't mind, would you like to come sit with me inside?"

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An incense stick's time later, Ning Fuyi sat together with Qiu Yi outside a pavilion filled with tea and refreshments. Two immortal attendants poured tea for them and retreated behind them.

Ning Fuyi sipped her tea, not caring about the crystal droplets on her lips, her eyes fixed on the two people in the pavilion.

This Jiang Li had said she had something to tell her, but after she had followed them in for so long, Jiang Li had only been chattering endlessly to Chu Qingqiu. The two didn't know what they were discussing, but Jiang Li was laughing brilliantly.

Although Chu Qingqiu didn't speak much, the atmosphere was still very harmonious.

"I say, Young Sect Leader," Qiu Yi's mocking voice rang out. "Those refreshments are for you to eat, not prayer beads for chanting. You've worn that square cake completely round."

Only then did Ning Fuyi shift her gaze from the pavilion. The square cake in her hand had indeed been worn smooth by her handling, so she turned and placed it in Qiu Yi's dish.

Before Qiu Yi's scolding could begin, she simply picked up the cake and stuffed it into Qiu Yi's mouth, blocking her voice.

While Qiu Yi was mumbling and cursing on this side, Jiang Li over there put a piece of dried fruit in her mouth. Her round eyes turned, and she leaned over to say: "Divine Venerable, I suddenly remember someone once said that the Divine Venerable and the Young Sect Leader don't get along well, but seeing them now, that Young Sect Leader seems to care about the Divine Venerable quite a bit?"

Chu Qingqiu paused in raising her teacup, her eyes lifting slightly to meet Ning Fuyi's gaze directly. Her heart jumped, and she lowered her eyes again.

Her red lips parted slightly: "I've heard that Medical Immortal Jiang Li is very fond of inquiring about trivial matters throughout the six realms<sup>2</sup>. Seeing you today, it's indeed true."

Jiang Li blinked at these words and sat up properly: "As a physician, I come into contact with many people, so I love hearing about others' affairs. Otherwise, just burying myself in treating illnesses and saving people would be too boring."

She quickly changed the topic and started discussing the architecture of Tranquil Mountain Palace again. However, as they chatted, she sensed something was wrong and immediately became serious, reaching out to feel Chu Qingqiu's pulse and exclaiming quietly.

"Quickly call someone..." Before she could finish speaking, Ning Fuyi, who had been sitting outside the pavilion, transformed into flowing light and appeared before her. Her pink lips were pressed tightly together, her phoenix eyes stern, as she went to support Chu Qingqiu's arm.

It seemed she had developed this reaction in the Divine Meteorite, instinctively responding. Her speed was even faster than Qiu Yi, who had just rushed over.

"Master!" Qiu Yi hadn't yet swallowed her mouthful of cake, speaking nervously.

"The Divine Venerable's immortal meridians are unstable. Quickly help her back to a windless place—I need to treat her immediately," Jiang Li said seriously, completely different from her previous demeanor.

As soon as she finished speaking, the two hurriedly helped Chu Qingqiu up. But Qiu Yi was very nervous and didn't know what to do for a moment. Added to the cramped space in the pavilion, movement was difficult.

"Move aside." Ning Fuyi pushed Qiu Yi away and, just like in the Divine Meteorite, placed Chu Qingqiu's arm over her shoulder, gently embracing her waist with her left hand. Their bodies suddenly disappeared.

The incident happened suddenly. After Ning Fuyi had placed the half-unconscious person down, she was pushed out of the room. Then she saw great green light emanating from within, with medicinal scents and floral fragrances seeping out through the door cracks, occasionally mixed with the smell of blood. But there was no sound at all, making her involuntarily anxious.

However, she didn't show it. Qiu Yi beside her was the opposite—tears and snot flowing as she muttered about unforgettable teacher's kindness, crying as if Chu Qingqiu had already passed away.

After a long time—so long that the sun set in the west, the moon was bright and stars were sparse, and myriad lights had been lit—the room finally became quiet. Jiang Li's weary voice rang out, saying that Chu Qingqiu couldn't see anyone right now and told them to leave first.

Only after there was no more presence outside the door did Jiang Li rise from the ground, so exhausted she had lost half her immortal aura. She casually used her shawl to wipe sweat and helped up Chu Qingqiu, whose face was pale as paper.

Earlier, she had witnessed with her own eyes the agony of being pierced by ten thousand steel needles, yet the woman before her had kept biting back her pain and enduring silently. She had nearly lost consciousness midway but never cried out.

Jiang Li couldn't understand why she insisted on bearing it all alone, but she admired her immensely.

"Actually, Divine Venerable, sometimes you don't need to be so resilient. Although you are honored as a Divine Venerable, you're not actually a god after all. Even gods need care and comfort from others. Bearing everything alone like this is too painful," Jiang Li couldn't help but say.

Chu Qingqiu didn't answer, only brushed away her disheveled hair, revealing clear features.

"However, I've already repaired your immortal meridians. I'll continue treating you over the next few days. Once your extraordinary meridians<sup>3</sup> return to normal and immortal energy protects you, the pain should lessen somewhat." Perhaps because they had successfully passed through the danger, Jiang Li's tone became relaxed again.

"I see the Young Sect Leader seems not to have left yet—she's wandering around downstairs," Jiang Li said, looking out the window and blinking.

"That's her temperament—she's always loved opposing me," Chu Qingqiu said weakly, closing her eyes.

"From what I can see, she doesn't seem to be opposing you," Jiang Li suppressed a smile, half-jokingly saying. "Rather, she likes you."

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**Footnotes:**

- <sup>1</sup> **Sect Leader Ningtian (凝天掌门)** - This refers to Ning Changfeng, whose sect leader title uses "Ningtian" (Condensing Heaven), which was mentioned in the translation guidelines.
- <sup>2</sup> **Six realms (六界)** - In Chinese cosmology, this typically refers to the six realms of existence: gods, demigods, humans, animals, hungry ghosts, and hell beings.
- <sup>3</sup> **Extraordinary meridians (奇经八脉)** - In traditional Chinese medicine and cultivation fiction, these are eight special meridian channels through which spiritual energy flows, distinct from the twelve regular meridians.